



PEACE IS EVERY STEP

THE PATH OF MINDFULNESS IN
EVERYDAY LIFE

Thich Nhat Hanh



The Big “So What”

In our modern life, most people are constantly worrying and chasing after new goals. We seek fulfilment, happiness and peace, not realizing that these are already in us. **By slowing down and getting in touch with what's in and around us, we can bring peace and joy to ourselves and others.** Nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize in 1967, Hanh shares how mindfulness can help us to manage negative feelings like anger, sorrow, and grief, and bring us true peace and happiness.



Introduction

The book is written in short chapters, organized into 3 key segments. In this summary, we'll outline:

- Key ideas and techniques for cultivating awareness and mindfulness;
- How to transform negative emotions and handle difficult psychological states; and
- How to master the art of mindful living and enjoy peace and happiness.



Cultivating Awareness & Mindfulness

We are often so busy planning for the future that we lose touch with the present. When we're not mindful, we are merely dreaming, and the people/ things around us are phantoms. **When we're mindful, everything becomes real and we experience the full lushness of life.**

KEY QUOTES

"Love, compassion, and altruism are the fundamental basis for peace."
- The Dalai Lama

"Peace is available in every moment, in every breath, in every step."

"Peace is present right here and now, in ourselves and in everything we do and see. The question is whether or not we are in touch with it."

"We are very good at preparing to live, but not very good at living."

Conscious breathing and smiling are 2 building blocks of mindfulness:



Conscious breathing. Breathing is an integral part of being alive. By focusing on your breathing, you bring yourself back to the present moment, and align your mind and body to focus on your breath.



Smiling. A smile can relax hundreds of muscles in your body, to bring awareness, calm and peace.

Most of us have an ongoing commentary in our heads – our minds constantly speculate and worry, and we can't switch them off. When we slow down and practice conscious breathing, we are resting our minds. We become more refreshed, and are in touch with the present moment.



Practicing Conscious Breathing

You don't need to be in a church to pray, and you don't need to be in a meditation hall to be mindful. **Conscious breathing and smiling can be done anytime, anywhere.**



Breathing exercises. Try these 2 simple exercises:

- o **Awareness of in-breath and out-breath:** As you breathe in, say to yourself, "Breathing in, I know that I am breathing in." As you breathe out, say, "Breathing out, I know that I am breathing out."
- o **Enjoying the present:** As you breathe in, say to yourself, "Breathing in, I calm my body," and imagine cool lemonade flowing through your body on a hot day. As you breathe out, say, "Breathing out, I smile," and feel yourself relax with a smile. Spend some enjoying the moment, saying, "Dwelling in the present moment, I know this is a wonderful moment!"



Sitting Meditation. Hanh explains various postures that you can use for your meditation, including half-lotus, full-lotus, cross-legged or just sit with your back straight and your hands resting on your lap. Unlike some meditation experts, Hanh believes that you should listen to your body - if your body is numb or in pain, shift your position or take a slow, mindful walk before resuming your position.

KEY QUOTES

"Simple practices like conscious breathing and smiling are very important. They can change our civilization."

"The source of a true smile is an awakened mind."

"Thinking is important, but quite a lot of our thinking is useless."

"We should be able to bring the practice from the meditation hall into our daily lives... Mindfulness can penetrate the activities of everyday life, each minute, each hour of our daily life, and not just be a description of something far away."

"Our appointment with life is in the present moment."



Mindfulness Cues. Hanh uses the sound of a bell to remind himself and his students to return to the present moment. You can practice this with any sound or item, e.g. each time you hear the sound of running water, or see rays of sunshine, use it as a reminder to take a break, breathe in and out, and savour the present moment.



Telephone Meditation. Our lives are somewhat controlled by our phones. We spend a lot of time on calls and messages, and they make us anxious. Before you answer or make your next phone call, pause and practice conscious breathing a few times, smiling and relaxing yourself.



Mindful Eating is an important practice, and can be very enjoyable. As a child, Hanh used to take his time to enjoy his cookies, taking as long as 30-45 minutes to savour each one. According to Hanh, even the Christian service of the Eucharist is essentially a practice of awareness - when Jesus shared his bread with his disciples, saying, "Eat this. This is my flesh", he wanted them to eat it in mindfulness.

- o **Tangerine Meditation.** As you enjoy a tangerine, consider its origins, as well as those of the tangerine tree. When you look deeply into the fruit, you'll see how it contains all elements of the universe - sunshine, rain and earth, and people who delivered the tangerine to you. As you peel and enjoy the fruit, observe the mist and its fragrance, the texture and flavours of each bite.
- o **Eating as a family.** Put aside everything you are doing. When the food is served, everyone breathes consciously (3x). Look at each person and give a heartfelt smile. Then, look at the food, contemplate its origins and its connection with the earth. Eat mindfully, enjoying the food and one another's presence. Focus your conversations, if any, on the food, rather than say, work problems or gossip about others.



Washing Dishes. Every we do is concurrently a means and an end. If you look at a task (e.g. washing dishes) as a chore that you have to complete to get to an outcome (clean dishes), you will dread it. But, if you wash the dishes mindfully and enjoy the moment, it becomes an end in itself.



Walking Meditation. Likewise, walking isn't just a means to get to a destination. Enjoy the walk itself, using walking

KEY QUOTES

"Practicing mindfulness enables us to become a real person. When we are a real person, we see real people around us, and life is present in all its richness."

"We must learn to stop from time to time in order to see clearly."

"When we are capable of stopping, we begin to see and, if we can see, we understand. Peace and happiness are the fruit of this process."

"Each time you look at a tangerine, you can see deeply into it. You can see everything in the universe in one tangerine."

"Breathing and smiling together is a very important practice."

"Practicing meditation is to go back to the present moment in order to encounter the flower, the blue sky, the child. Happiness is available."

"Each step we take will create a cool breeze, refreshing our body and mind. Every step makes a flower bloom under our feet."

meditation. Let go of the past/ future and just immerse in the present moment. Enjoy each step, coordinating your steps with your breathing (e.g. taking 4 slow steps with each in-breath and 4 steps with each out-breath). Notice how your feet make contact with the earth; kiss the Earth with each step, sharing your feeling of peace and contentment with it.



Driving Meditation. Driving is stressful to many people, as they get upset with traffic, red lights, and other drivers. Don't treat the car as a tool to get somewhere, but as an extension of yourself. Enjoy your drive, and treat red lights/ traffic jams as opportunities for conscious breathing, rather than obstructions to your journey. If you're driving to take a break from your problems and to release stress, consider a walking meditation instead.



Breathing Room. Hanh recommends having a breathing room in your house, where you can practice breathing and smiling. Whenever you're upset, go to the room, take time to breath, smile and recover yourself. You can place a "bell" in the room – this provides the cue for you to start your conscious breathing, and informs your family members that you're taking time to recover.



Owning the Present

Often, being present simply means to notice what's around us, without over-thinking it. **Rather than do everything with a goal, learn to appreciate each moment and activity for itself.** This may feel counter-intuitive in our goals-driven society. However, if you're not mindful, you may end up chasing what you already have, e.g. if you are not conscious of the happiness in you, you'll keep doing more to try to be happy. To own the future, you need to own the present moment.



Life as a masterpiece. If you try to study a flower with the goal of producing the best piece of art, you won't succeed. Instead, if you look deeply into the flower and enjoy it, the joy, peace and appreciation inside you will be expressed naturally in your art-form. In fact, it will show up in everything that you do.



Hope as an obstacle. Hope for the future makes today's hardship easier to bear, but if we focus so much on the future, we'll miss what we already have now. **Rather than place all**

KEY QUOTES

"When we use a car, we are ourselves and the car."

"The past is gone, the future is not yet here. If we do not go back to ourselves in the present moment, we cannot be in touch with life."

"Since we cling to our hope in the future, we do not focus our energies and capabilities on the present moment."

your energy into hoping for the future, channel it fully into the present moment, so you can create your breakthrough now.



Now that we understand how to cultivate mindfulness, let's look at how to deal with difficult feelings.

Transmuting Negative Feelings

 **Flowers vs Waste.** Most of us love flowers but despise waste/garbage. However, a flower will become waste after it wilts. Waste is made into compost, which becomes a part of the flower. They are different forms of the same thing. Likewise, we reject negative feelings and embrace positive ones, when both are a part of us.

 **The River of Feelings.** Hanh likens our feelings to the river; each drop of water represents a different feeling. Rather than get swept away by the flood of feelings, learn to sit by the river bank and observe. Breathe consciously, recognize you have an unpleasant feeling, identify what it is (e.g. anger, fear), and face it with love and understanding (rather than rejection or clinginess).

 **Cooking our Potatoes.** We can't eat raw potatoes, but we don't throw them away. Instead, we cook them to make them edible. Likewise, healing cannot come from running away or cutting off what we don't like about ourselves. We must learn to face them and transform them. Don't be angry with your anger. Instead, use love to nurture it, and peace to reconcile with it.

 **Transforming Feelings.** Imagine you're feeling afraid. To transform it:

- o **Identify the feeling.** Look deeply at it with mindfulness, so you can recognize it as fear.
- o **Accept the feeling.** Don't detach yourself from the fear or reject it. Instead, unite with it. Use mindfulness to guide the fear, and

KEY QUOTES

"Our feeling is not separate from us or caused merely by something outside us; our feeling is us, and for the moment we are that feeling."

"If we face our unpleasant feelings with care, affection, and nonviolence, we can transform them into the kind of energy that is healthy and has the capacity to nourish us."

"Instead of acting as if we can dispose of parts of ourselves, we should learn the art of transformation."

"As soon as we understand the causes and nature of our feelings, they begin to transform themselves."

"As long as mindfulness is present, you will not drown in your fear."

realize that you're more than your fear. The more you nurture mindfulness, the stronger it'll be and the better it can keep your unpleasant feelings in check.

- o Soothe the feeling, like how a mother will soothe an upset baby. The fear will ebb under your tender care.
- o Free the feeling. Now that you know you can handle your fear, release it with a smile.
- o Look deeply at it. Examine what has caused the fear, so you can address the root cause(s).

This method is comparable to psychotherapy, where the therapist works with the patient to identify the source of the pain. In both cases, the patients must be willing to free themselves of beliefs or behaviours that bring them pain.



Dealing with Anger



Mindfulness of anger. Anger and hatred can consume us and make us lose control. Yet, they are a part of us, and we need not fear nor reject them. Instead, manage them through mindfulness. When you feel angry, rather than focus on the person or issue that "made" you angry, pause to focus on your breathing, and bring in mindfulness to tend to your anger. Your priority is to calm your anger, like how a fireman puts out a fire. You should pursue the cause of the fire only *after* the flames are doused.



Pillow-pounding. Anger-management experts at times encourage people to "release" their anger through pillow-pounding. Hanh recommends against this - pillow-pounding may exhaust you briefly, but it doesn't remove the cause of anger. In fact, you're practicing how to express anger. The only way to remove anger is to look deeply into it, identify the causes, and plant new seeds to transform the situation, like how sunshine brings life to vegetation just by shining on it.



Walking meditation. When you are angry, it helps to surround yourself with nature and fresh air, while doing a walking meditation. Enjoy the environment, your breathing and steps, and calm your anger until you're ready to look deeply at it.

KEY QUOTES

"Feeling his mother's tenderness, the baby will calm down and stop crying. The mother is your mindfulness, born from the depth of your consciousness, and it will tend the feeling of pain."

"Anger...is like a blazing flame that burns up our self-control and causes us to say and do things that we regret later."

"Like a fireman, we have to pour water on the blaze first and not waste time looking for the one who set the house on fire."

"When we understand the nature, the roots, of our anger, we will be freed from it."

 **The roots of anger** are usually pride, mistrust, desire, unrest, and/or misunderstanding (of ourselves and others). These causes arise from us, not others, i.e. no one can “make” us angry. Instead, understanding the reasons behind others’ behaviours will reduce our own negative reactions.

Internal Formations

When something unpleasant happens (e.g. we feel someone has belittled us, or has treated us unfairly), a “knot” forms internally. We’ll typically avoid these knots as they bring us pain. Yet, **the longer the knots remain, the faster they become. It’s best to untie the knots once they form, and you do that through awareness and understanding.**

By observing our pain (e.g. becoming aware of the feelings, images, words etc. that we associate with something or someone), and looking deeply to understand why we respond that way, we shine a light on our deepest fears and pain. With awareness and understanding, we can begin to transform them.

 **Living Together.** When we live with someone, our happiness are intertwined. To be happy together, we must help one another to untie the knots as they form, and to transform these internal formations.

 **Look into your hand.** Meditate on your hands. If you look deeply into them, you can see the essence of your parents and ancestors, as well as your connection with all other elements of the universe.

 **Parents** often unintentionally pass on their seeds of pain to their children. For example, someone who was frequently punished by his father may subconsciously feel angry, and this anger surfaces under similar situations with his own child. By practicing mindfulness, we become aware of these seeds. When we understand, forgive and transform the feelings, we bring peace and happiness to ourselves, our parents and our future generations.

KEY QUOTES

“Seeing and understanding are the elements of liberation that bring about love and compassion.”

“If we do not untie our knots when they form, they will grow tighter and stronger.”

“The root cause of any internal formation is a lack of understanding.”

“The well is within us, and if we dig deeply in the present moment, the water will spring forth.”

“We usually think that parents have to nourish their children, but sometimes the children can bring enlightenment to the parents and help transform them.”



Healing with Love, Understanding and Compassion



Nourish Healthy Seeds. There are 2 layers to our consciousness – seeds, and the manifestations of these seeds. When we lose our temper, we're manifesting our anger and concurrently planting new seeds of anger. When we practice smiling and mindful breathing, we're feeling and planting new seeds of peace, joy, and mindfulness. A reservoir of healthy seeds helps us to manage negative emotions more easily.



Ask, "What's not wrong?". Avoid asking "What's Wrong?", as it invites our pain to surface. Instead, ask "What's not wrong?", and allow these positive elements to heal us.



Don't Blame. When a plant doesn't grow well, we look into the reasons behind it (e.g. lack of fertilizers, sunlight, water). Yet, when we face issues with people, we tend to blame them. **Look after the people around you, the same way you would a plant. With love and understanding, they will flourish.**



Understanding. Love and understanding are 2 sides of the same coin. **When you truly understand something or someone, you will naturally feel love and compassion for them.**

- o **Compassion.** Having compassion means to suffer with others. Start by meditating on, or looking deeply into, someone who's undergoing physical pain or illness. Over time, you can shift your meditation to more subtle forms of suffering. When you're able to feel compassion for those who've caused you pain, and understand why they behaved that way, your negative feelings toward them will change. They'll eventually sense your shift, and reconciliation will come more naturally.
- o **Love.** Like compassion, real love is built on understanding. Similar to how we accept that fire is both useful and dangerous, when we can accept people's good and bad, flowers and waste, we can be happy and peaceful together.



Hugging Meditation. Hugging can bring joy and comfort. Before you hug someone, practice conscious breathing to remove distractions. During the hug, breathe 3 times consciously to become fully present, so you can truly appreciate the person you're hugging.

KEY QUOTES

"To succeed, we need to cultivate a good reserve of refreshing seeds."

"No blame, no reasoning, no argument, just understanding."

"When you understand, you cannot help but love. And when you love, you naturally act in a way that can relieve the suffering of people."

"When we are in contact with another's suffering, a feeling of compassion is born in us."

"One word, one action, or one thought can reduce another person's suffering and bring him joy."

 **Bringing people** together. Hanh encourages us to create opportunities for old people to spend time with, or live with their *grandchildren*, as it brings everyone great joy. He also advocates *communities of mindful living* to provide support and a sense of belonging for the practice of mindfulness.

Engaged Mindfulness

During the Vietnam war, monks and nuns had to choose between their contemplative life and stepping out to help those in need. Hanh did both, and coined the term “Engaged Buddhism”. He believes that *awareness through mindfulness practice isn't enough; you must also take insightful action*, e.g. mindfully helping others, taking each breath and step mindfully to transmit joy and peace.

Mindful Living

As a peace activist, Hanh strongly advocates *mindful living not just for personal happiness, but also to bring peace to our troubled world*.

Inter-Being

Hanh uses the term “interbeing” to describe how everything is interconnected and interdependent on everything else. A piece of paper in your hand can only exist because of the tree it came from, and by extension, the sunshine, rain and earth which nourished the tree. It's also made possible by the supply chain of people, machines, transportation etc. to deliver the paper to you, and by extension, their families, raw materials etc. Even your vision and brain are needed to make the paper “real”. In short, *if you look deeply enough, a piece of paper “inter-is” all elements; there's nothing that's not in it*.

◆ **Flowers and Waste.** Earlier, we've touched on how flowers and waste inter-are. Likewise, poverty vs wealth, beauty vs vileness, are all but concepts in our head. Someone's wealth is built on another's poverty, and it's dangerous to isolate ourselves using labels and concepts. *Only by seeing “inter-being” in the world can we understand how we're responsible for everything, good or bad*.

KEY QUOTES

“We have to find ways for old and young people to live together again. It will make all of us very happy.”

“Practicing mindfulness is much easier with a community.”

“Once there is seeing, there must be acting. Otherwise, what is the use of seeing?”

“Practicing breathing and contemplating our body, feelings, mind, and objects of mind, we practice peace in the present moment. This is living mindfully.”

“As thin as this sheet of paper is, it contains everything in the universe in it.”

“The truth is that everything contains everything else. We cannot just be, we can only inter-be. We are responsible for everything that happens around us.”

 **Non-duality.** We can't understand something or someone by observing them from the outside, as separate entities. We need to become one with them. To do that, you must look deeply, and allow yourself to be lost in the thing/ person, and vice versa.

 **Looking Deeply.** When we look deeply enough into a tree, we'll be the tree, and can put ourselves in its shoes. We'll see that we're made of the sun, air, rain, and everything is a part of us. If more people practiced mindfulness, we'll understand the problems in ourselves, our society and Earth, live responsibly and secure our future.

 **Peace is Strength.** People who push hard for political, social, environmental, or other changes often burn out after repeated setbacks. By cultivating inner peace through mindfulness, we gain clarity, strength and patience to sustain consistent action.

The Art of Mindful Living

 **Connect with nature.** We are children of Nature; **Being connected to, or being one with nature, is an integral part of mindful living.** We'll become aware that when we throw away an orange peel, it'll soon form part of a flower, but when we throw away a plastic bag or bottle, it takes much longer to do so. Such mindfulness will shape our choices.

 **Bring peace with peace.** Often, peace movements are done with protests, anger and frustration, when they should involve love, understanding and compassion. To promote peace, we must first be peaceful. To achieve true peace, we need people who understand the needs and suffering of *all* parties, and can adopt non-dual views rather than take sides.

 **No superior side.** It's easy to side with the "good people" and condemn the "bad guys". But, if we had the same upbringing and influences as a murderer, rapist, or robber, we'd likely have behaved the same way. Rather than blame others for mistakes and pain of the past (e.g. world wars, civil wars, global warming), we should treat these as compost for our flowers of the future. Hanh shares his poem "Call me by my true names", which speaks of how we are both the "good" and "bad" things around us. When we can see that all things inter-are, our hearts will be opened.

KEY QUOTES

"To comprehend something means to pick it up and be one with it. There is no other way to understand something."

"With clarity, determination, and patience – the fruits of meditation – we can sustain a life of action and be real instruments of peace."

"Real strength is not in power, money, or weapons but in deep, inner peace."

"We are imprisoned in our small selves, thinking only of the comfortable conditions for this small self, while we destroy our large self."

"Peace work means, first of all, being peace... That is why it is so important for us to practice mindfulness, to acquire the capacity to look, to see and to understand."

"During any conflict, we need people who can understand the suffering of all sides... We need links. We need communication."

"Every side is 'our side'; there is no evil side."



Citizenship. Our circumstances are defined by our perception. By changing ourselves and how we see things, we can take action based on insight. We can live responsibly, and ask the same of our leaders.



Ecology of Mind. The seeds that we plant in our minds spill over to all aspects of our lives. To stop polluting the world with violence, exploitation and chemicals, we must start by protecting our minds from the pollution of media content that sow seeds of violence, fear and anxiety in ourselves and our children.



Reconciliation

What if you'd hurt others, and they now see you as an enemy?

- First, apologize, and make a commitment to change yourself.
- Then, work on transforming yourself; that's the only way to show that you mean what you say. When you're transformed, the other person cannot help but notice the difference and will forgive you.

Likewise, you can take the initiative to reconcile with your "enemies". To practice and test your compassion, try listening to someone who has hurt you. When you no longer feel the need to take sides on the situation, can empathise with their pain, and sincerely want to ease their suffering, you're truly beginning to understand.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Hanh uses many powerful analogies and simple examples in this book to help us understand abstract concepts and philosophies. His peaceful essence and deep insights emanate from the book, and reading the book mindfully is in itself a calming and enriching experience.

Hanh ends the book with "The 14 Precepts of the Order of Interbeing", which summarize his key teachings and philosophies. He reminds us that all concepts and ideologies, including his teachings, are merely guides, and we should discover our own truth through living fully.

KEY QUOTES

"Meditation is to look deeply into things and to see how we can change ourselves and how we can transform our situation... the situation is mind, and mind is situation."

"When you begin to see that your enemy is suffering, that is the beginning of insight. When you see in yourself the wish that the other person stop suffering, that is a sign of real love."

"If we genuinely try to understand the suffering of another person, we are more likely to act in a way that will help him overcome his suffering and confusion, and that will help all of us."

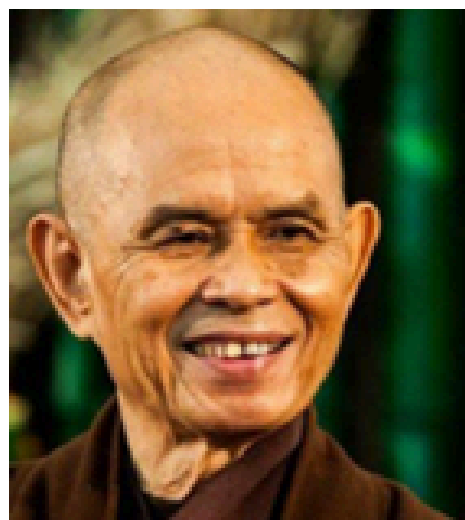
"There is nothing to chase after. We can go back to ourselves, enjoy our breathing, our smiling, ourselves, and our beautiful environment."

"All systems of thought are guiding means; they are not absolute truth."

"Truth is found in life and not merely in conceptual knowledge."

For more details about Hanh, his teachings and legacy, go to www.plumvillage.org.

About the Author



Thich Nhat Hanh (born 1926) is a global spiritual leader, poet and peace activist, known for his teachings and bestselling writings on mindfulness and peace. Hanh was ordained a Buddhist monk at the age of 16. In 1967, he was nominated by Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. for the Nobel Peace Prize, for his contributions to end the hostilities in Vietnam.

Because of his peace activism, he was exiled from Vietnam for 39 years. Hanh continued to teach, lecture and write, traveling widely to spread the message of peace and brotherhood. In 1975, he established the Sweet Potato community, which later became Plum Village, the West's largest and most active Buddhist monastery.

More recently, Hanh founded international "Wake Up" programs to train mindful living practices, opened numerous monasteries as well as Europe's first "Institute of Applied Buddhism" in Germany. He also led events for politicians (in the US, UK, Ireland, India, Thailand), and organizations like Google and The World Bank. Hanh suffered a stroke in 2014; he's still practicing in Plum Village as of 2016.

KEY QUOTES